Jude 3–4 — Leader / Learner Guide

The Battle Cry: Contend Earnestly for the Faith · Study 2 of 6 · Source: The Gospel Vault

Big Idea and Context

> **Big idea:** Jude set aside a warm letter about our common salvation to urge believers to contend for the faith once for all handed down, because men had slipped in who turned grace into license and denied the Lord.

Verses 3–4 are the hinge of the letter. They tell us why Jude wrote and what the threat is. Everything after is built on them.

- **vv. 1–2:** who the readers are.
- **vv. 3–4:** the change of plan, the battle cry, and the crisis.
- **vv. 5–16:** warnings and portraits.
- **vv. 17–23:** the believer's response.
- **vv. 24–25:** He is able.

Four Anchor Phrases in Verses 3–4

Verse	What it says	Teaching point
v. 3	our common salvation	Shared by all believers. The warm letter Jude meant to write.
v. 3	contend earnestly (*epagōnizesthai*)	Only here in the NT. Athletic effort *for* the faith.
v. 3	once for all handed down	A fixed, completed content received from the apostles.
v. 4	grace into licentiousness; deny our only Master and Lord	The two charges. Grace misused, and the Lord denied.

Do not overstate: Jude does not say whether the intruders were ever believers, and nothing in the argument turns on it. He tells us what they do and where it leads.

Teaching Flow

1. **The change of plan (v. 3a).** Jude wanted to write about the common salvation and was compelled to write this letter instead.
2. **The battle cry (v. 3b).** *Epagōnizesthai* — fight *for* the faith; the faith is a closed deposit.
3. **The infiltrators (v. 4).** They crept in unnoticed; they are marked out in the record of Scripture; they turn grace into license and deny the Lord.

Clarify While Teaching

- **"Marked out beforehand":** some Reformed readers see eternal reprobation; the context points to what Scripture wrote long ago (vv. 5–11).
- **"The faith":** the apostolic message — not a personal statement of belief. It is handed down, not invented.
- **Is free grace license?** Critics (e.g., MacArthur) say so. Free Grace answers that Jude condemns using grace as an excuse for sin, and that grace itself teaches godliness (Titus 2:11–12).
- **Avoid witch hunts.** Honest questions and struggles are not the marks Jude lists.

Discussion and Close

1. What is the "common salvation" you most want to protect in your family or church?
2. How can we contend *for* the faith without fighting *against* people?
3. How would you answer someone who says free grace leads to license?

Close: Point ahead to vv. 5–11: Jude proves his point from history. The pattern of grace abused is not new, and neither is God's answer to it.